

The Disintegration of Pakistan and the Emergence of Bangladesh: An Analysis of Factors and Disparities

1. Introduction

The emergence of Bangladesh in 1971 was not merely the result of a sudden political crisis but the inevitable conclusion of a twenty-four-year history of systemic exploitation and internal colonialism. When Pakistan was created in 1947 on the basis of the "Two-Nation Theory," it was a unique geopolitical experiment: a state consisting of two wings, East and West Pakistan, separated by 1,600 kilometers of hostile Indian territory. While religion was intended to be the unifying bond, it quickly proved insufficient to bridge the gaping differences in language, culture, and ethnicity. From the very inception of the state, the ruling elite in West Pakistan treated East Pakistan not as an equal province, but as a colony to be exploited for resources and revenue. This structural imbalance created a deep sense of alienation among the Bengalis, which eventually solidified into a potent nationalist movement.

2. Geographical and Demographical Disconnect

The physical separation of the two wings created insurmountable logistical and psychological barriers. The 1,600-kilometer divide meant that there was no ease of movement for the common people; only the wealthy could afford air travel, effectively isolating the populations from one another. More importantly, the demographic reality was ignored by the state machinery. East Pakistan was home to approximately 56% of the total population, yet the capital, military headquarters, and administrative center were all located in West Pakistan (first Karachi, then Islamabad). This geographical centralization meant that the majority of the population was physically removed from the seat of power, requiring Bengalis to travel thousands of miles at great expense merely to lobby for their basic rights or apply for central government jobs.

3. The Language Movement: Cultural Suppression

The first cracks in the unity of Pakistan appeared with the attempt to suppress the Bengali language. The West Pakistani leadership, led by Governor-General Muhammad Ali Jinnah, viewed Urdu as the symbol of Muslim unity and Bengali as a "Hinduized" language. In 1948, when Dhirendranath Datta proposed in the Constituent Assembly that Bengali be made one of the state languages, the proposal was summarily rejected. This cultural chauvinism culminated in 1952 when the government tried to impose Urdu as the sole state language.⁷ The police firing on student protesters on February 21, 1952, resulting in martyrdoms, was the turning point. It signaled to the Bengalis that their identity was under attack.⁸ This event planted the seeds of secular Bengali nationalism, shifting the political discourse from religion (Islam) to linguistic and cultural identity.

4. Economic Exploitation: The "Two-Economy" Theory

The most devastating factor was the economic disparity, often described by Bengali economists as the "Two-Economy" policy. East Pakistan was the primary earner of foreign exchange for the country, contributing between 50% to 70% of total export earnings, primarily through the export of jute and tea. However, these earnings were systematically diverted to finance the industrialization of West Pakistan. While the East earned the money, the West spent it. West Pakistan received approximately 70% of the import licenses and 75% of the total development budget. The foreign aid that Pakistan received from the West and international bodies was also unequally distributed, with nearly 80% of aid utilized for projects in the West, such as the Indus Basin Replacement Works, while flood control projects in the East were ignored.

5. Disparity in Planning and Infrastructure

The discriminatory nature of the central government was evident in the Five-Year Plans. In the First Five-Year Plan (1955–60), the per capita expenditure in East Pakistan was significantly lower than in the West. This trend continued in the Second and Third Plans. As a result, the infrastructure in West Pakistan—roads, dams, power plants, and factories—developed rapidly, while the East

remained an agrarian hinterland. By 1969-70, the per capita income in West Pakistan was 61% higher than in East Pakistan. This transfer of wealth was so blatant that economists estimated a transfer of approximately \$2.6 billion from East to West Pakistan over two decades. The Bengalis found themselves buying goods manufactured in West Pakistan at inflated prices, protected by tariffs, while their own raw materials were sold cheap.

6. Administrative and Political Exclusion

The administration of Pakistan was thoroughly dominated by the West Pakistani elite, particularly the Punjabis and Mohajirs. Bengalis were systematically excluded from key decision-making positions. In the Central Civil Service, Bengalis held only about 16% of the positions. Even in the Foreign Service, they represented only about 15% of the diplomats. This meant that policies affecting the East were drafted by bureaucrats who had little understanding of or sympathy for the region's problems. Politically, the dismissal of the United Front government in 1954 and the imposition of military rule by Ayub Khan in 1958 were seen as attempts to deny the Bengali majority their democratic right to rule. The "One Unit" scheme in the West and the principle of "Parity" were artificial mechanisms designed to neutralize the numerical majority of the Bengalis in the parliament.

7. Military Imbalance and Defense Vulnerability

Perhaps the most dangerous disparity was in the defense sector. The British colonial theory of "Martial Races" was adopted by Pakistan, favoring recruitment from the Punjab and Pashtun regions. As a result, Bengalis constituted a negligible 5% of the officer corps and only about 10% of the other ranks. The defense budget, which consumed a massive portion of the national revenue (often over 50%), was spent almost entirely in the West, fueling the economy there while the East paid the taxes. The 1965 Indo-Pak war exposed the vulnerability of East Pakistan; the region was left virtually defenseless as the bulk of the military was deployed on the Western front. The Pakistani leadership's doctrine that "the defense of the East lies in the West" was rejected by the Bengalis, who realized that in a major conflict, they were expendable.

8. The Six-Point Movement and Agartala Conspiracy Case

In response to this overwhelming disparity, Sheikh Mujibur Rahman presented the Six-Point Programme in 1966. It was a charter for survival, demanding a federal form of government where the central government would control only defense and foreign affairs, while the provinces would control their own currency, taxation, and trade. The West Pakistani establishment viewed this not as a demand for rights, but as a secessionist plot. In a desperate bid to suppress him, the government fabricated the Agartala Conspiracy Case in 1968, charging Mujib with treason. However, this backfired spectacularly. Instead of destroying him, the trial unified the entire Bengali nation behind him, elevating him to the status of "Bangabandhu" and leading to the Mass Upsurge of 1969 that toppled the dictator Ayub Khan.

9. The 1970 Cyclone and the Election Mandate

The psychological severance of ties occurred in November 1970, when the Bhola Cyclone killed nearly half a million people in coastal East Pakistan. The central government in Islamabad showed a callous indifference, with relief efforts being slow and inadequate. This reinforced the feeling that East Pakistan was a colony ruled by a foreign power. In the subsequent General Election of 1970, the Awami League won a landslide victory, securing 160 out of 162 seats in the East and an absolute majority in the National Assembly. This was a democratic mandate for the Six Points. However, the refusal of the military junta and Zulfikar Ali Bhutto to transfer power to the elected representatives proved that the West would never accept Bengali rule, making a united Pakistan impossible.

10. Conclusion

The disintegration of Pakistan was the result of a consistent failure to build an inclusive nation-state. The West Pakistani ruling elite's reliance on military force, their refusal to share power, and

their economic plundering of the East created a situation where the Bengalis had no option but to seek independence. The genocide launched via Operation Searchlight on March 25, 1971, was the final act that severed the union. Bangladesh emerged not just as a reaction to immediate violence, but as the solution to decades of systemic inequality, proving that religion alone cannot hold a nation together in the absence of justice, equity, and democracy.

Sector-Wise Disparities: East Pakistan vs. West Pakistan (1947–1971)

1. Economic Disparity (Budget & Development)

Despite having the majority of the population (56%), East Pakistan received a fraction of the national budget.

Sector / Indicator	East Pakistan (Bangladesh)	West Pakistan	Nature of Disparity
Revenue Expenditure	~25%	~75%	The central government spent three times more in the West than in the East.
Development Expenditure	30% (approx.)	70% (approx.)	Most infrastructure (dams, roads, power plants) was built in the West.
Per Capita Income (1969-70)	314 Rupees	504 Rupees	An average West Pakistani earned 61% more than an average Bengali.
Foreign Aid Utilization	~20%	~80%	Aid money was used to build industries in Karachi and Punjab, while the East paid the loans.
Inflation & Price	High Prices	Lower Prices	Essential goods (rice, wheat) were often cheaper in the West due to subsidies.

2. Trade & Foreign Exchange Earnings

East Pakistan was the primary earner of foreign currency, but West Pakistan was the primary spender.

Sector / Indicator	East Pakistan	West Pakistan	Nature of Disparity
Export Earnings	50% - 70%	30% - 50%	East Pakistan's Jute & Tea were the main earners of foreign currency.
Import Expenditure	~30%	~70%	Foreign currency earned by the East was used to import machinery and luxury goods for the West.
Transfer of Resources	Net Loser	Net Gainer	An estimated \$2.6 billion (in 1970 value) was transferred from East to West over two decades.

3. Administrative Disparity (Civil Service)

Key decision-making positions were almost exclusively held by West Pakistanis.

Sector / Indicator	East Pakistan	West Pakistan	Nature of Disparity
Central Govt. Civil Service	16%	84%	Bengalis were systematically excluded from high-ranking bureaucratic posts.
Foreign Service (Ambassadors)	15%	85%	Diplomatic missions were dominated by West Pakistanis.
Headquarters	None	All	Capital, State Bank, PIA, and Secretariat were all in the West.

4. Defense & Military Disparity

This was the most critical disparity, leaving East Pakistan defenseless and without representation in the armed forces.

Sector / Indicator	East Pakistan	West Pakistan	Nature of Disparity
Military Officers	5%	95%	The officer corps was dominated by Punjabis and Pashtuns.
General Soldiers	10%	90%	Recruitment policies favored "Martial Races" of the West.

Sector / Indicator	East Pakistan	West Pakistan	Nature of Disparity
Defense Spending	~10%	~90%	Defense budget fueled the economy of the West (salaries, contracts, bases).
Military HQs	None	All (Rawalpindi/Karachi)	Army, Navy, and Air Force headquarters were all located in the West.
Ordnance Factories	1	16+	During the 1965 war, East Pakistan was left militarily vulnerable.

5. Social & Educational Disparity

Investments in human capital (education, health) were heavily skewed toward the West.

Sector / Indicator	East Pakistan	West Pakistan	Nature of Disparity
Education Funding	Low	High	The West received massive grants for universities and scholarships.
Growth in Primary Schools	Decreased/Stagnant	Significant Increase	Number of schools grew much faster in the West.
University Scholars (1947-67)	Increase by ~15x	Increase by ~30x	Higher education opportunities were created disproportionately in the West.
Hospital Beds	~26% of Total	~74% of Total	Healthcare infrastructure was vastly superior in the West.

The Agartala Conspiracy Case (1968)

1. Introduction

The Agartala Conspiracy Case was a landmark sedition case filed by the government of Pakistan during the regime of Field Marshal Ayub Khan. Officially titled "State vs. Sheikh Mujibur Rahman and Others," it was a desperate attempt by the West Pakistani ruling elite to suppress the rising tide of Bengali nationalism and the demand for regional autonomy led by the Awami League.

2. Background and Context

- **The Six-Point Movement:** In 1966, Sheikh Mujibur Rahman launched the Six-Point Programme, often termed the "Magna Carta" of Bengali rights. It demanded significant autonomy for East Pakistan, threatening the central government's control.
- **Government Repression:** Fearing the popularity of the movement, the Ayub regime arrested Sheikh Mujib in May 1966. While he was already in detention, the government fabricated a new, more serious charge to label him as a traitor and separatist.
- **The Conspiracy Theory:** The government intelligence agencies (ISI) claimed they had unearthed a plot by Bengali civil and military officials to separate East Pakistan through an armed revolt with Indian assistance.

3. Case Details

- **Official Name:** *State vs. Sheikh Mujibur Rahman and Others.*
- **Popular Name:** Agartala Conspiracy Case (*Agartala Shorojontro Mamla*), named after the Indian city of Agartala (Tripura) where the alleged conspirators were said to have met Indian officials.
- **Filing Date:** The case was publicly announced in **January 1968**.
- **The Accused:** A total of **35 people** were accused.
 - **Accused No. 1:** Sheikh Mujibur Rahman.
 - **Accused No. 2:** Lt. Commander Moazzem Hossain.
 - **Accused No. 3:** Steward Mujibur Rahman.
 - Other accused included high-ranking Bengali civil servants (CSP officers) and military personnel from the Army, Navy, and Air Force.
- **The Charges:** The accused were charged under **Sections 121-A and 131** of the Pakistan Penal Code for conspiring to wage war against Pakistan and deprive it of its sovereignty over East Pakistan.

4. The Special Tribunal

- **Formation:** The government amended the law to try the accused not in a regular court but in a **Special Tribunal**.
- **Location:** The trial was held inside the heavily guarded **Dhaka Cantonment**.
- **Judges:** The tribunal consisted of three judges:
 1. **Justice S.A. Rahman** (Chairman, from West Pakistan).
 2. **Justice M.R. Khan** (Member, Bengali).
 3. **Justice Maksum-ul-Hakim** (Member, Bengali).
- **Defense:** Sir Thomas Williams, a British Queen's Counsel (QC), arrived in Dhaka to defend Sheikh Mujib, further internationalizing the issue.

5. Public Reaction and The Mass Upsurge (1969)

Instead of discrediting Sheikh Mujib, the trial turned him into a national hero. The people of East Pakistan viewed the case as a conspiracy by the government against the Bengali people.

- **Student Movement:** The All Party Student Action Committee (SAC) launched the **11-Point Programme**, incorporating the Six Points and demanding the withdrawal of the case.
- **Turning Point (Killing of Sergeant Zahurul Haq):** On **February 15, 1969**, one of the accused, **Sergeant Zahurul Haq**, was shot dead by Pakistani guards while in custody in the Dhaka Cantonment.
- **Explosion of Anger:** This killing sparked a violent mass uprising. An angry mob burned down the State Guest House where the tribunal chairman, Justice S.A. Rahman, was staying, forcing him to flee.

6. Withdrawal and Release

Faced with an uncontrollable "Mass Upsurge" (Gonobhyutthan) and the breakdown of law and order, the Ayub Khan government was forced to surrender.

- **Date of Withdrawal:** On **February 22, 1969**, the government withdrew the Agartala Conspiracy Case.
- **Release:** All accused, including Sheikh Mujibur Rahman, were released unconditionally.

7. Significance and Aftermath

- **Birth of "Bangabandhu":** On **February 23, 1969**, at a massive reception at the Race Course Maidan, student leader Tofail Ahmed bestowed the title "**Bangabandhu**" (Friend of Bengal) upon Sheikh Mujibur Rahman.
- **Fall of Ayub Khan:** The failure of the case and the resulting uprising led to the resignation of President Ayub Khan in March 1969.
- **Road to Independence:** The case united the Bengali nation like never before. It solidified the Awami League's popularity, leading to their landslide victory in the **1970 General Elections** and eventually the **Liberation War of 1971**.

8. Conclusion

The Agartala Conspiracy Case was a political blunder by the Pakistani rulers. Intended to crush the demand for autonomy, it ironically accelerated the emergence of Bangladesh. It transformed Sheikh Mujibur Rahman from a party leader into the undisputed father of the Bengali nation.

The 11-Point Programme of 1969

1. Introduction

The 11-Point Programme was a historic charter of demands formulated by the All Party Student Action Committee (SAC) in January 1969 during the Mass Upsurge in East Pakistan. While Sheikh Mujibur Rahman's Six-Point Programme demanded regional autonomy, the students' 11 Points broadened the movement by incorporating demands of the working class, peasantry, and the general public, effectively uniting the entire population against the Ayub Khan regime.

2. Formation of SAC

To launch a united movement against the autocratic rule of President Ayub Khan and the Agartala Conspiracy Case, leaders from various student organizations (including East Pakistan Chhatra League and East Pakistan Chhatra Union) formed the All Party Student Action Committee (Sarbadaliya Chhatra Sangram Parishad) on January 5, 1969. They announced the 11-Point Programme to spearhead the movement.

3. The 11 Points (Detailed Breakdown)

The 11 points can be categorized into educational, political, and economic demands:

- **Point 1: Education Reform**
 - Rejection of the Sharif Commission Report on education and the Hamoodur Rahman Commission Report.
 - Restoration of the rights of students and full autonomy for universities.
 - Subsidized schooling and college fees (reduction of monthly tuition fees by 50%).
 - Guarantee of job opportunities for students after education.
- **Point 2: Restoration of Democracy**
 - Restoration of parliamentary democracy based on **universal adult franchise**.
 - Restoration of freedom of the press and freedom of speech (repeal of the Press and Publications Ordinance).
- **Point 3: Autonomy (Integration of Six Points)**
 - Full implementation of the **Six-Point Programme** of the Awami League for regional autonomy of East Pakistan.
 - Reorganization of the federal government, leaving only defense and foreign affairs to the center.
- **Point 4: Economic Demands for West Pakistan**
 - Establishment of a sub-federation in West Pakistan, giving full autonomy to the provinces there (Sindh, Baluchistan, NWFP).
- **Point 5: Nationalization**
 - Nationalization of banks, insurance companies, and all big industries (including jute trade).
- **Point 6: Farmers' Rights**
 - Reduction of taxes and levies on farmers.
 - Exemption of land revenue for land holdings up to certain limits.
 - Fixing fair prices for jute and sugarcane.

- Withdrawal of the certificate system against farmers.
- **Point 7: Workers' Rights**
 - Fair wages and bonuses for workers.
 - Right to form trade unions and the right to strike.
 - Provision of education, housing, and medical facilities for workers.
- **Point 8: Flood Control**
 - Immediate implementation of effective flood control measures in East Pakistan.
 - Proper utilization of water resources.
- **Point 9: Withdrawal of Repressive Laws**
 - Withdrawal of all emergency laws, safety acts, and preventive detention ordinances used to suppress political opposition.
- **Point 10: Foreign Policy**
 - Withdrawal from military pacts like SEATO (Southeast Asia Treaty Organization) and CENTO (Central Treaty Organization).
 - Adoption of a neutral and independent foreign policy.
- **Point 11: Release of Prisoners**
 - **Withdrawal of the Agartala Conspiracy Case.**
 - Immediate and unconditional release of all students, workers, and political leaders, including Sheikh Mujibur Rahman, arrested under false charges.
 - Cancellation of arrest warrants against political activists.

4. Significance of the 11 Points

- **Unification:** Unlike the Six Points which focused on middle-class Bengali autonomy, the 11 Points addressed the grievances of farmers (jute prices, taxes) and workers (wages). This turned the movement from a political struggle into a **mass upsurge**.
- **Catalyst for 1969 Uprising:** The popularity of these demands led to the violent uprising in 1969, forcing the government to withdraw the Agartala Conspiracy Case and release Sheikh Mujib.
- **Fall of Ayub Khan:** The momentum generated by the 11-Point movement made Ayub Khan's position untenable, leading to his resignation in March 1969.
- **Precursor to 1971:** The unity forged by the 11 Points consolidated Bengali nationalism, paving the way for the landslide victory in the 1970 election and the eventual Liberation War.

5. Conclusion

The 11-Point Programme was a revolutionary charter that bridged the gap between the educated elite and the common masses. It acted as the final nail in the coffin for the Ayub regime and served as a crucial stepping stone toward the independence of Bangladesh.

The Mass Upsurge of 1969 (Gonobhyutthan)

1. Introduction

The Mass Upsurge of 1969 was a historic popular movement in East Pakistan (now Bangladesh) that took place during the months of January, February, and March 1969. It was a spontaneous explosion of public anger against the decade-long autocratic rule of President Ayub Khan and the filing of the Agartala Conspiracy Case. This movement is often termed the "dress rehearsal" for the Bangladesh Liberation War of 1971.

2. Causes and Background

- **The Agartala Conspiracy Case:** The primary trigger was the government's false sedition case against Sheikh Mujibur Rahman and 34 others, which the public saw as a conspiracy to hang the Bengali leader.
- **The 11-Point Programme:** The All Party Student Action Committee (SAC) united the students, workers, and peasants under an **11-Point Programme**, which included the Awami League's Six Points.
- **Economic Disparity:** Years of economic exploitation and neglect of East Pakistan by the West Pakistani rulers created deep resentment among the masses.
- **Autocratic Rule:** The suppression of democracy and freedom of speech under Ayub Khan's "Basic Democracy" system had alienated the people.
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3. Timeline of Major Events (Jan–March 1969)

The movement escalated through a series of tragic killings that fueled public fury:

- **January 4:** Formation of the **Student Action Committee (SAC)** by leaders of various student organizations (DUCSU, Chhatra League, Chhatra Union).
- **January 20 (Martyrdom of Asad):** Student leader **Amanullah Asad** was shot dead by police during a procession near Dhaka Medical College. His death turned the student movement into a mass uprising.
- **January 24 (Mass Upsurge Day):** A teenager named **Matiur Rahman** was shot dead by police during a protest. This day is observed as *Mass Upsurge Day*. The movement spread from Dhaka to the entire province.
- **February 15 (Killing of Sgt. Zahurul Haq):** **Sergeant Zahurul Haq**, one of the accused in the Agartala Conspiracy Case, was brutally shot dead while in custody inside the Dhaka Cantonment. This incident made the public uncontrollable, leading them to burn down the State Guest House and the home of the chief judge.
- **February 18 (Killing of Dr. Zoha):** **Dr. Shamsuzzoha**, the Proctor of Rajshahi University, was bayoneted to death by the Pakistani military while trying to protect his students. He is considered the first martyred intellectual of Bangladesh.

4. The Climax: Withdrawal and Release

The continuous strikes, curfews, and violent clashes paralyzed the government machinery.

- **Withdrawal of Case:** On **February 22, 1969**, the Ayub Khan government succumbed to public pressure, withdrew the Agartala Conspiracy Case, and unconditionally released Sheikh Mujibur Rahman and other accused.
- **"Bangabandhu" Title:** On **February 23, 1969**, at a massive reception at the Race Course Maidan (now Suhrawardy Udyan), student leader Tofail Ahmed conferred the title **"Bangabandhu"** (Friend of Bengal) upon Sheikh Mujibur Rahman on behalf of the nation.

5. Outcomes and Significance

- **Fall of Ayub Khan:** The movement forced Field Marshal Ayub Khan to resign on **March 25, 1969**, handing over power to General Yahya Khan.
- **Restoration of Adult Franchise:** The movement forced the restoration of the "One Man, One Vote" principle, paving the way for the general elections of 1970.
- **Rise of Nationalism:** It bridged the gap between the urban middle class and the rural masses, creating a unified Bengali national identity.
- **Road to 1971:** The victory in 1969 gave the Bengali people the confidence that they could defeat the West Pakistani military regime, directly leading to the landslide victory in the 1970 elections and the Liberation War of 1971.

6. Conclusion

The Mass Upsurge of 1969 was a watershed moment in the history of Bangladesh. It was not just a movement to release a leader, but a revolution that shattered the iron grip of the Pakistani military dictatorship and set the stage for the emergence of an independent Bangladesh.

Quick Reference: Key Martyrs of 1969

Name	Date of Martyrdom	Identity
Amanullah Asad	Jan 20, 1969	Student Leader (Law Student)
Matiur Rahman	Jan 24, 1969	School Student (Class 9)
Sgt. Zahurul Haq	Feb 15, 1969	PAF Sergeant (Accused in Agartala Case)
Dr. Shamsuzzoha	Feb 18, 1969	Professor & Proctor, Rajshahi University